Memoirs of a Nun on Fire

By Philomene Long

INTRODUCTION

Philomene Long was born in Greenwich Village. Among the very first sounds she heard were those of poets howling their poems and jumping out the windows. At the age of eighteen she entered a convent as a wild teenager. After five years behind cloister walls she escaped in the middle of the night down the side of a mountain to Venice West where she lived among the poets, saints, and mad ones. This is her autobiographical poem . . . Memoirs of a Nun on Fire by Philomene Long.

"You are worldly, Sister Marie Philomene," the Mother
Superior had said in the parlor
bent over me, tall, angular, aristocratic
like the silhouette *of* a praying mantis.
"Even your voice, its inflections. Worldly."

At that I was to kneel on the spot. Kneel with no
excuses.
Blind obedience.

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Drop to the floor like a swatted fly.

Eyes lowered, lips *closed.*
I wiggled. My veil fluttered.
My knees bent a little, then locked. I would not.

Back straight, head erect,
my eyes wide, cool, and I hope vacant,
I stared into her triangular face. I turned. Left through
the dim corridors *of* no time *or* season.

In my room I reached through the silence, and as if
from a great height,
watched my hands take the scissors,
begin to cut name tags *off* veils,
stockings, underwear. Everything.

All over the room,
threads and scraps of my name,
"Sister Marie Philomene" like tiny white clouds far
beneath my feet.

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I knew I would leave that night. Just walk out.
Five years within this cloister. An enclosure of silence.
Latin. Eyes fixed to the floor. Black robes, medieval
gestures. In the most secret recesses,
a thousand daily deaths.

At the end of the hall the life-size crucifix. Christ's
bruised knee,
the level of our lips.
A well-kissed knee.

Through these corridors
we glide through our own ghosts.
Muted light. Fluid movements.
Everything clean. Silent and clean.
"I have loved, O Lord, the beauty of Thy house."

But here some things feel dirty.
Like in my dreams.
In the convent I do not dream of the good sisters. Each
night it is a dark man who follows me.

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He is tall, thin, and wears black. All black.
His half smile is repulsive.
He wants to kiss me. Every night in my dreams.
Sometimes he removes my veil,
runs his fingers through my hair.
Once he does kiss me.
I am frightened. I tell another sister.
She says the dark man is myself.

And then-the night I was seduced
by God disguised as a fat black fly.
As a Bride of God I was told to experience the Mystical
Union I must make my mind empty, an erased
blackboard.
I contemplate the blackness of space,
the millions of light years between the stars.
I stretch my mind until it is no longer fixed anywhere.

I became the Bride of the Expansive Black.
I kiss it. Marry it. Its deep silence.

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But it is difficult to contemplate the Immensity while enduring a small but persistent itch.

Daily I work shoveling the convent's garbage into the incinerator. The flies and yellow jackets are very friendly.
At times the golden insects cover my black serge habit like a jeweled mantle, as the flies circle my head.
At first I do not know a fly, that one fly has crept into my ear to rest. I suppose it has awakened, confused, and is trying to escape.
Lost deep within my ear canal, it buzzes with mounting intensity. Its buzz is as loud and wide as the universe I am contemplating. Finally, I know it is not God, but only a fly.
Or is it God disguised as a fly? Is it the buzz of God?

The fly buzzes with growing desperation.
As the fly's delirium grows, so does mine
given the heat, the perspiration,
the itchy habit, and

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the frantic buzzing of that fly. That Fly?

When it emerges into my outer ear
I open the side of my head gear and the fly flies out.
At this moment, this very moment, I see it at the corner of my eye an enormous black fly.
It hangs in mid-air as if to look at me for a moment.
The most beautiful fly I've ever seen

But what did the nuns see as they sat silently behind me
everyone motionless except one nun and
a hovering fly besides her?
I will never know. No one ever mentions it.
No one ever mentions anything personal.

Beat. Beaten. Beatific.
I am on my knees before the bed, the crucifix.
This particular night is exceptionally dark.
It is this night I am to understand I am a poet.
Saturday night. Time to whip ourselves again.
I wonder is Cardinal McIntyre doing this?

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But I will do it right this time.
Five years within the convent and I have not yet done it right.
Each time the hand that holds the chains has exerted its own will.
I say to the night, "I will tonight. I will beat myself until I bleed."

My body, mind-one thing
I raise the chain high up. Higher.
That way it will come down with greater force
to beat, beat. To beat, to be beaten. Higher. Faster.
Body, mind, chain-one thing. One will.
To strike repeatedly. To beat to blood.

It ends.
I run my fingers over my back. There is blood.
For the first time-blood.

A small amount. But I did it. "Beautiful blood," I say.
I remove my habit.

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I run my fingers over the spot. Yes. It is blood.
Beatific blood. Beatific spot.
Slowly, I turn in awe to see it. It, indeed, is beautiful.
But it, my beatific spot. . . is a mosquito bite!

I stand in the center of the room. Let loose a mighty laugh. "Beatific mosquito! Beatific bite!"

I, who have been the Bride of flies,
have become the Bride of mosquitoes.
"Holy proboscis! Probe of fire!"
(Didn't Saint Rose of Lima, out among the mosquitoes so that they might bite her, say their hum sounded to her
like a choir of angels?)

"O Holy Night! The mosquitoes are quietly biting Little fly. Great night."

If you would have looked into this dark corner,

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you would have found Philomene, a Philomene who no
longer hid her heart under crossed arms,

Hers was a song of . . .
No, it was deeper even:
it was a prayer, as the priest mutters
from the altar holding up the Host.
Her heart thumping in this forgotten corner as she
prayed. You would see her dare to look at her own body,
in the stark black night
Her body, golden serpentine,
glowing cheeks, glistening eyes, crimson tongue
In this night of black finger, her slick long body rising
rising in the blackness-slowly, very slowly turning,
turning in the unseeing dreadful hole of night.
The night, its burning lips, the night of kisses.
She danced. Burning bride of God.
In the Grand Silence, you could hear Philomene whisper,
"I am a poet."

But I will always be a nun.

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Always in my dreams I am a shabby nun. There are flies
under my habit
and my robes are in bits and pieces.
I will always have an affinity for the extreme.
Even now I prefer the company of a St. Francis of Assisi
taking his clothes off in public,
or St. Simeon Stylites
who sat for years atop a high column,
or St. Joan of Arc
who heard voices and dressed in men's clothes.
Even now I prefer to live among
the poets, saints and mad ones of Venice West.
I know no other way but to leap
into the Holy Fires.

Burn. Burn. Must burn.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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